

Agile! The Good, the Hype, and the Ugly (Bertrand Meyer)

Book Summary

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This is a practical book that enables the reader to benefit from the good ideas of agile methods while staying away from the bad ones. Agile methods are a mix of horrible and great ideas. Instead of trying out Scrum, Extreme Programming, Lean Software, and Crystal all on one's own, this book provides a description and assessment of their underlying ideas.

First, those methods are described without the usual sermons and anecdotes. Second, the underlying ideas are scrutinized and assessed, thereby separating the useful from the harmful ones. Agile methods and their texts put three difficulties in the reader's way:

1. *Partisanship*: While it's common for their inventors to argue in favour of their inventions, proponents of agile methods ignore the rules of rational discourse and ask the reader to join their cult, which is inappropriate for engineering problems.
2. *Intimidation*: Agile texts dismiss previous approaches to software development as outdated and their users as rigid and backwards. Who wants to argue against "agile" when all of this word's opposites have negative meanings?
3. *Extremism*: Proponents of some agile methods insist on the application of a method in its entirety, which discourages a more differentiated view on the techniques that make up a specific method.

While previous books criticizing agile methods were rather timid, this book will call out the bad ideas without undue deference.

The first chapter is a summary of agile ideas. In the second chapter, the rhetoric of agile texts is analyzed. Chapter three is a description of traditional plan-based software development—to which agile methods are the antidote. Chapters four to eight review agile ideas: principles, roles, practices, and artifacts.

Those chapters do not focus on individual methods, but on their many commonalities. Scrum, Lean, XP, and Crystal are then presented in chapter nine as combinations of those principles already discussed, each with their one single big idea emphasized.

Chapter ten described precautions organizations should take when adopting agile methods. Chapter eleven is the final assessment; it classifies agile ideas into three categories: the good, the hype, and the ugly.

This book is not a comprehensive guide to software development, but a critique of existing approaches. Authors usually argument by gut feeling, by experience (e.g. projects saved by agile approaches and failed by ignoring them), logical reasoning, and, ideally, empirical analysis (for which there is usually too little data available). This book relies mostly on analytical reasoning, combined with personal experience and anecdotes for illustrative purposes.

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